Q+A →

Can't Stop the Music

Maestro **Zubin Mehta** is conducting two concerts in Mumbai dedicated to the works of Richard Strauss

Q. You've conducted many prestigious orchestras worldwide. What stood out to you about the Symphony Orchestra of India (SOI) during your first collaboration in 2023?

I was surprised to find the SOI is a mix of musicians from around the world, with only a few Indian members. The orchestra, led by Khushroo Suntook, is of very high quality. Their performance of Mahler's Symphony was on par with some of the best orchestras globally.

Q. Your concerts on Aug. 24 and 25 at NCPA, Mumbai, are dedicated to Richard Strauss. What challenges and rewards do you find in conducting his works?

My early days in Vienna shaped my approach to Strauss. I studied these works closely and have conducted *Don Juan*, *Ein Heldenleben* and *Four Last Songs* for decades. I'm excited to bring my experience to the SOI musicians, who are talented enough to handle these technically demanding pieces.

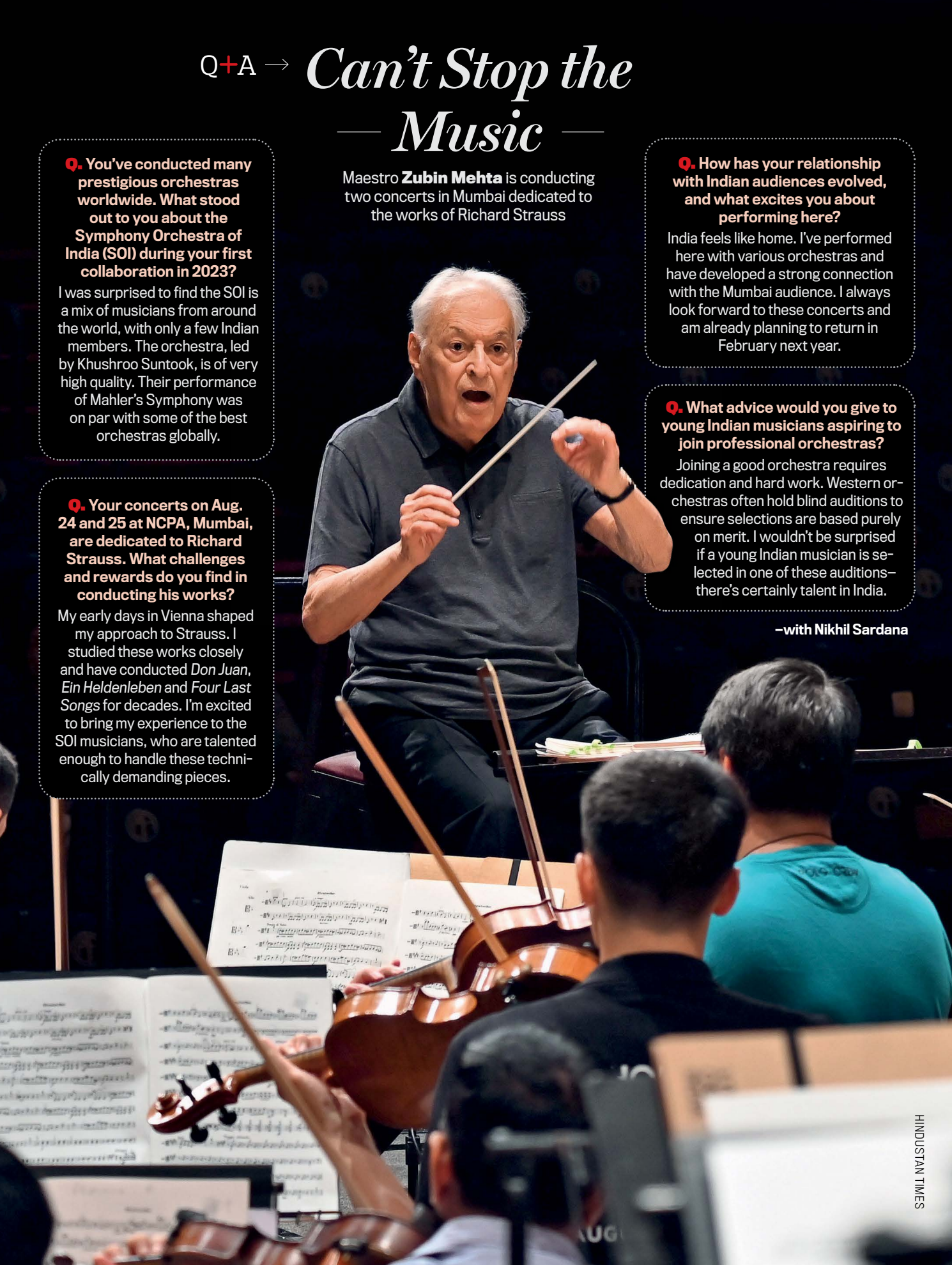
Q. How has your relationship with Indian audiences evolved, and what excites you about performing here?

India feels like home. I've performed here with various orchestras and have developed a strong connection with the Mumbai audience. I always look forward to these concerts and am already planning to return in February next year.

Q. What advice would you give to young Indian musicians aspiring to join professional orchestras?

Joining a good orchestra requires dedication and hard work. Western orchestras often hold blind auditions to ensure selections are based purely on merit. I wouldn't be surprised if a young Indian musician is selected in one of these auditions—there's certainly talent in India.

–with Nikhil Sardana



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